

Midnight's CHILDREN

The novel that won the Booker of the Bookers and inspired a generation to imagine India in English is yet to be outlived

■ By S. Prasannarajan

I was born in the city of Bombay... Once upon a time. No, that won't do, there is no getting away from the date: I was born in Doctor Narlikar's Nursing Home on August 15th, 1947. And the time? The time matters, too. Well then: at night. No, it's important to be more... On the stroke of midnight as a matter of fact." Saleem Sinai, the speaker of these words, arrived at a time when India Imagined in English was a placid province. The monotony of chiselled realism didn't have much to offer other than Malgudi as a destination for literary sightseers. It was a time when the Indian story was either a social screed inhabited by stereotypes or an oriental fable with an exaggerated morality. Saleem's first cry that chimed with India's freedom shattered the idyll. The story of India was reborn. The art of the novel, which was of European origin, got a tropical makeover that would make India the hottest item in the lit marts of London and New York.

Midnight's Children, the second novel by Salman Rushdie who at the time of its publication in 1981 was only a few weeks older than Saleem and whose first book *Grimus* was such a non-event, was a declaration of freedom from the dead certainties of fiction in English—E of the Queen's of course. In its art and architecture, *Midnight's Children* exuded a kind of creative exuberance that was hardly 'English'. It was marvellously shapeless, luminously loose, and in the rustle of its pages merged the lost murmurs of memory. This novel was a site on which language breached the border to keep pace with the temptations of history. Lovely Lassi. Funtabulous Falooda. And more of that *bhel-purified* English from an ex-copy writer was a necessary medium for paraphrasing a chutnified history. Well, as the novel shocked and savaged the assumptions of those who grew up in the literary ghettos of social realism, critics were busy tracing the fictional genealogy of

Saleem. Some heard in his voice the echoes of Oskar's drum beats in Gunter Grass' *The Tin Drum*. We could go further down in pages to the roots of inspiration, to Laurence Stern and Gogol, to Kafka and Marquez. A novel that strikes a fine balance between ideas and action is not characteristically English. It has to be sufficiently European or Latin American. *Midnight's Children* may be indebted to some of the most audacious pieces of fiction in Europe and Central America, but it is vociferously Indian. In its polyphony and in its structural chaos, it is Indian with a calligraphic I.

The novel would become a cult classic, and the novelist a cultural icon. It won the Booker as well the Booker of the Bookers when the Prize turned 25. And this novel won something larger too. It redeemed India from the fairy tales of the Orient, and it made the history of the subcontinent an adjective to the existence of the living. It made India possible in a million other words. It inspired a generation to imagine India in English. It gave them confidence—and a model. The Indian Novel in English is not exotic any longer. Its accents and attitudes are accessible and acceptable. It is worthy of big prizes and big advances. And India has become one of the most written about countries in fiction—an Indian novel is written almost every other day. This celebration in the marketplace of metaphors is a tribute to the first cry of that bastard child of history: Saleem Sinai. Still, every grandchild of the midnight won't accept

his indebtedness to Rushdie. Some of them think they can achieve literary adulthood only by defying or lampooning the Master. That is why De-Mythifying Salman Rushdie has become such a coming-of-age rite for literary parvenus. Only those who are intimidated by it take *Midnight's Children* to be a novel that has to be outlived. The Great Indian Novel has not grown beyond that whirling story told by a Bombay *chokra* who left the town to argue with the world. ■

SALMAN RUSHDIE, writer, 1983

"There is a kind of intellectual totalitarianism in India and there are things that are appalling."